A distinguished Indian, Sir Ashutosh Mukherjee (1864–1924), a trained lawyer and an educationist, was travelling in a first class coach (as he had every right to do). A British passenger, perhaps a planter or a jute mill manager, boarded the train and reluctantly took the upper berth in Mukherjee's compartment. He did not like sharing the compartment with the sleeping 'native' and, when he saw Mukherjee's sandals, he threw them out of the moving train.

When Mukherjee awoke and saw his sandals gone he guessed what had happened. He then took the sleeping Briton's jacket from its peg and threw it out of the window. The Briton searched for his jacket in the morning. He asked Sir Ashutosh if he knew where it was. The calm reply was: 'Your coat has gone to fetch my slippers.' The train then pulled into a station, others appeared and any confrontation was avoided. [108]

ADDENDUM

Some humour on the East India Railway

Here are a few extracts of humorous incidents related to Indian Railways, collected from *Eastern Railway Magazine*, 1953. [109]

Whose property?

There is a story about an angry passenger who complained to a railway official that he had a cinder in his eye from one of the engines, and it cost him £1 to have it taken out and have his eye seen by a doctor.

The aggrieved passenger asked: 'What are you going to do about it?'

To this the official answered tactfully, after saying that he was sorry to learn of the problem, 'We shall do nothing, sir! We have no further use of the cinder, and from a legal point of view the cinder was not yours. No doubt we could institute proceedings against you for removing our property, but in this case, we shall take no further steps in the matter.'

The train stopped because…

This was a frequent query—'Why has the train stopped?'

Whenever a passenger train stopped outside its scheduled stops, railwaymen went to some pains to give passengers the reason for the delay. There was a case, however, during World War I when a passenger train came to a stop near a junction to allow a war freight to pass through ahead of it, and the guard of the passenger train, who had been sworn to secrecy about the traffic movement, said, 'We have stopped because the signalman up the line has red hair and the engine driver cannot drive past him until he pulls his head in.' He was, needless to say, not believed by the passengers.

The old woman and the driver

This story has been in circulation in the eastern part of India for a pretty long time. The Bankura Damodar Railway (BDR) was infamous for its slow running. It is said that the drivers used to stop trains midway to pick up passengers from villages. One such driver had a regular passenger, an old woman, who used to carry her produce of vegetables daily